

THE SWORN BACHELORS · PART ONE

Donald × Emma

The Billionaire Who Swore Never to Love

Three poor boys grew up as neighbours in Ajegunle. Life scattered them, and fifteen years later they met again as millionaires and swore on their childhood rooftop never to fall in love. Seven years later, all three have, at the same time, and none of them will admit it.

DONALD Hiding Emma	MICHAEL Hiding Sophia	GEOFFREY Hiding a dead man's file
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45

SCENES

~49

MINUTES

10

TWISTS TO GUESS

LAGOS

SETTING

The cast

DONALD IRWIN

(37). Self-made billionaire and CEO of Every's Conglomerate (ports, telecoms, EveryPay fintech, Eko Atlantic real estate). Brilliant and generous, and controlling to the bone. He has to be in charge of everything because, once, he was in charge of nothing.

MICHAEL McCLAREN

(37). Famous film director and Donald's best friend. Loud, charming and always joking, and secretly hiding a woman named Sophia.

ROSS

(45). Emma's mentor. Warm, and hiding something terrible.

MARCUS VANE

(52). Old-money tycoon. Smiling and patient, with a grudge older than anyone knows.

ADAEZE

(30). Donald's PA, the only person who tells him the truth.

MALLAM ISA

(60s). Suya seller near the old Ebute-Metta railway yard. He has fed Donald since Donald was a boy.

DR. & MRS. REARDON

Emma's parents, both doctors.

MAMA McCLAREN

Michael's mother, the compound's loudest voice. TUNDE. The school bully from Primary 5B. MR. IRWIN, Donald's father. INSPECTOR BELLO. NARRATOR.

EMMA REARDON

(27). Analyst at Every's. Her parents are both doctors and she refuses their money. She is sharp, stubborn and funny, and she does not take orders from anyone she doesn't respect.

GEOFFREY DUROSE

(37). Heir of Durose Holdings and Donald's best friend. Quiet, a financial genius, and secretly hiding a file about his late father.

DEBBY

(38). Ross's girlfriend.

MAMA IRWIN

(64). Donald's mother. Fragile since the night her husband died.

TOBI

(26). Emma's best friend at work. Speaks Pidgin and has no filter.

JAMES REARDON

(31). Emma's older brother, a musician the family pushed out.

YOUNG DONALD, YOUNG MICHAEL, YOUNG GEOFFREY

(ages 9–15). Neighbours in one Ajegunle compound.

Three secrets, one rooftop

All of this is happening at the same time. Nobody can question anybody without exposing himself.

Donald

HIDING

He's in love with Emma

WHAT GIVES HIM AWAY

Two plates of jollof, a woman's shoe, smiling at his phone

Michael

HIDING

He's in love with Sophia, a writer suing his studio

WHAT GIVES HIM AWAY

A contact saved as "Script Supervisor", late-night whispering

Geoffrey

HIDING

A hidden file about his late father and a dead man called Elias Hart

WHAT GIVES HIM AWAY

Leaving early, lying about "board meetings", a woman called Olivia

How to enjoy this PDF

- Tap any scene in the contents to jump straight to it. Your PDF app's bookmarks list every scene too.
- At 10 cliffhangers there is a **Guess the twist** box. Tick your answer in the PDF (the boxes are real checkboxes in most PDF apps), then keep reading.
- When a twist is revealed, a green box appears in the scene with a link back to your guess. All answers are on the last page.
- **PREAMBLE** marks the childhood and origin story. **SECRET** marks scenes where one of the brothers is hiding something.

Scenes

01	One Wall, One Ball	PREAMBLE	0:00
02	Break Time	PREAMBLE	1:42
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23	The Pantry	SECRET	26:12
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26	"You Decide Everything"		28:33
27	The Tracker		29:26
28	The Breakup		30:17
29	Geoffrey Knows	SECRET	GUESS ★ 31:34
30	The Confession		32:33
31	On Her Terms		33:45

32	Who Marcus Is		34:37
33	The Plan	SECRET	35:18
34	Suya and Trains	GUESS ★	36:08
35	Friday		37:23
36	Powerless	SECRET	38:07
37	The Message in the Video		39:11
38	Sign It	GUESS ★	40:21
39	What His Father Was Carrying		41:16
40	She Doesn't Wait to Be Saved		42:57
41	The Empty Box		43:41
42	The Truth About Papa	GUESS ★	44:43
43	The Proposal That Went Wrong	GUESS ★	45:35
44	The Second Ask		46:34
45	The Fool on the Rooftop	SECRET	47:51
★	Answer key and your detective score		

One Wall, One Ball

EXT. FACE-ME-I-FACE-YOU COMPOUND, AJEGUNLE — EVENING — THIRTY YEARS AGO

NARRATOR Before the billions, the towers and the lies, there were three poor boys, one thin wall and one football made of nylon bags.

A crowded compound. Washing hangs on lines, a single tap drips, children everywhere and a kerosene stove smokes. Three doors stand side by side: the IRWINS, the McCLARENS and the DUROSES. Three nine-year-old boys, barefoot, kick a ball made of nylon bags tied with rubber bands between two bricks for a goal: YOUNG DONALD, YOUNG MICHAEL and YOUNG GEOFFREY.

YOUNG MICHAEL *(commentating like a TV presenter)* Michael McClaren has the ball! He passes one! He passes two! The crowd is going crazy! It's a GOAAAL!

YOUNG DONALD That's not a goal. The ball went over the brick.

YOUNG MICHAEL The brick is short! It's a goal in my heart!

YOUNG GEOFFREY *(writing in a tattered exercise book)* That's the fourth goal you've scored "in your heart" today. In real life, Donald is winning three-nil.

The ball flies and lands in a pot of stew outside Mama Michael's door. Silence. MAMA McCLAREN appears with a wooden spoon.

MAMA McCLAREN WHO KICKED THIS BALL?!

Michael and Geoffrey immediately point at Donald. Donald steps forward without hesitation.

YOUNG DONALD It was me, Ma. I'll fetch water for you for one week.

MAMA McCLAREN *(softening)* ...Two weeks. And bring back my spoon.

She goes in. The boys burst out laughing.

YOUNG GEOFFREY Why do you always take the blame?

YOUNG DONALD *(shrugging)* Somebody has to be in charge.

NEPA takes the light. The whole compound shouts "Ahhh!" in the dark. The three boys sit on the step together, shoulder to shoulder.

YOUNG GEOFFREY My papa says one day he'll build something so big we'll never sleep in the dark again.

YOUNG MICHAEL My papa says I talk too much.

YOUNG DONALD *(looking at his own door)* My papa says if you're poor, you have to be twice as careful. *(beat)* I'm going to be three times.

Break Time

EXT. AJEGUNLE COMMUNITY PRIMARY SCHOOL — DUSTY FIELD — DAY

A school bell clangs. Dozens of children in faded brown-and-cream uniforms pour onto a dusty field. The three boys, now eleven, rush out with an old leather ball. Their opponents, PRIMARY 5B, are bigger, with a giant boy called TUNDE as captain.

TUNDE Ajegunle Three! Today we'll beat you like a drum!

YOUNG MICHAEL *(through a rolled-up paper "microphone")* Ladies and gentlemen, the big boys are talking! But talking doesn't score goals!

The match. Donald plays in defence, shouting orders at everybody, even his own goalkeeper.

YOUNG DONALD Michael, LEFT! Geoffrey, stay back! Nobody moves until I say!

YOUNG MICHAEL Who made you coach?

YOUNG DONALD I did!

Tunde shoves Geoffrey into the dust. Geoffrey's exercise book flies out of his pocket and lands open, full of numbers. Tunde laughs and stamps on it. Donald walks straight up to Tunde, who is a head taller.

YOUNG DONALD Pick it up.

TUNDE Or what?

YOUNG DONALD *(not blinking)* Or you'll find out what "or" means.

A long stare. The crowd of kids goes "Ooooh!" Tunde blinks first, picks up the book and dusts it off. Michael whoops. The bell rings. The three boys sit under the mango tree sharing one meat pie, carefully broken into three exact pieces by Geoffrey.

YOUNG GEOFFREY One meat pie. Three boys. Thirty-three point three percent each.

YOUNG MICHAEL One day, I'll buy you each a whole meat pie factory.

YOUNG DONALD One day, nobody will push any of us again.

NARRATOR Donald was the protector. Michael was the dreamer. Geoffrey was the brain. And between the three of them, they had exactly one meat pie.

The Night That Made Donald

INT. IRWIN ROOM, AJEGUNLE COMPOUND — NIGHT / EXT. ROOFTOP — DAWN

A kerosene lamp. YOUNG DONALD (12) does homework on the floor. His MOTHER stirs stew. MR. IRWIN's chair is empty.

MOTHER Your papa promised meat today. It's payday. The company pays at night, he said.

YOUNG DONALD When I'm big, my company will pay in the day. So nobody walks home in the dark.

A hard knock. Two POLICEMEN stand at the door, hats in their hands. The spoon falls.

POLICEMAN Madam... your husband. By the bus stop. Robbers. They took everything he was carrying.

His mother screams and collapses. Neighbours rush out of every door. Young Donald doesn't cry. He stares at the empty chair.

YOUNG DONALD *(whispering)* Never again. Never again will I be powerless.

DAWN. The rusty compound rooftop. Donald sits alone at the edge with dry, red eyes. The zinc creaks. Michael climbs up, then Geoffrey. Nobody says anything. They just sit down on either side of him.

After a long time, Michael takes out a sachet of biscuits, his only breakfast, and puts it in Donald's hand.

YOUNG MICHAEL *(quietly)* You don't have to talk.

YOUNG GEOFFREY We'll just sit.

Donald's chin trembles, but he doesn't cry. He leans his shoulder against Michael's.

YOUNG DONALD *(barely audible)* Promise me something. Whatever happens, we protect each other.

**YOUNG MICHAEL &
YOUNG GEOFFREY** We protect each other.

NARRATOR That night, a boy stopped crying. Over the years, he also stopped trusting, stopped resting and stopped letting anything happen that he didn't control. *(beat)* It would make him very rich. It would also make him very, very hard to love.

The Goodbye

EXT. COMPOUND ROOFTOP, AJEGUNLE — NIGHT — THREE YEARS LATER

The boys are fifteen. Below, a battered lorry is being loaded with the McClarens' few belongings. A shiny black Mercedes, completely out of place, waits at the gate for the Duroses. The three boys sit on the roof one last time. Between them is a handwritten paper: THREE BOYS VENTURES — CAPITAL: ₦3,000. Their savings from four years of selling pure water and recharge cards.

YOUNG MICHAEL Enugu. My papa's company transferred him to Enugu. I don't even know anybody in Enugu.

YOUNG GEOFFREY *(staring at the Mercedes)* My papa came home last week and said "something happened." Now we have a car with a driver and a house in Ikoyi. *(beat)* He won't tell me what happened. He just says, "Don't ask, Geoffrey."

YOUNG DONALD *(very quiet)* And I'm staying. Mama can't move. Not like this.

Silence. Then Donald picks up the share certificate and tears it carefully into three pieces. He hands one to each of them.

YOUNG DONALD Nobody can ever say this company belongs to one person. Keep your piece. Whatever happens, whoever becomes what... one day we put it back together.

YOUNG MICHAEL *(voice cracking, trying to joke)* When I'm a famous director, I'll come back in a Ferrari.

YOUNG GEOFFREY You can't even ride a bicycle.

YOUNG MICHAEL I'll have a driver!

They laugh, and then they hug, three skinny boys holding on too tight. Below, a horn honks twice from the Mercedes.

MAMA McCLAREN Michael! The lorry is leaving!
O.S.

One by one, they climb down. Donald stays on the roof alone, holding his piece of paper, and watches the lorry and the Mercedes drive away in opposite directions.

Separate Roads

MONTAGE — FIFTEEN YEARS IN TWO MINUTES

NARRATOR Phones got lost. Numbers changed. Pride made each of them wait for the other to call first. For fifteen years, three brothers became three strangers.

Quick cuts.

LAGOS. Sixteen-year-old Donald sells recharge cards in traffic in the rain, then hauls goods at Apapa port at night. At twenty-two, he signs the lease for a tiny logistics office with one truck. At twenty-seven, he stands in front of a fleet of fifty trucks with IRWIN LOGISTICS painted on the side, and he isn't smiling, just counting.

ENUGU. Michael films weddings with a borrowed camera and gets chased out of one by an angry bride's mother. In a half-empty Lagos cinema, his first film premieres. Then a packed premiere, red carpet, flashes. MICHAEL McCLAREN, DIRECTOR.

LONDON. Geoffrey graduates top of his class, alone, with no family in the audience. Then he is in Lagos in his father JACOB DUROSE's huge cold office, taking over Durose Holdings after the old man's funeral. He opens a drawer, finds his old piece of the ₦3,000 certificate and stares at it.

Three men, in three cities, each take out a torn piece of paper on a lonely night and put it away again.

NARRATOR By thirty, all three were millionaires. All three were alone. And not one of them knew the other two had made it.

↑ All scenes

The Reunion

EXT. AJEGUNLE — STREET OUTSIDE THE OLD COMPOUND — DAY — SEVEN YEARS AGO

Busy Ajegunle street. Okadas, hawkers, children. A black Range Rover pulls up outside the old face-me-I-face-you compound, now crumbling, with a FOR SALE sign on the gate. DONALD (30) steps out in a sharp suit and sunglasses. Kids crowd around the car.

KID Oga! Range Rover! Na your own?

DONALD *(handing out naira notes)* It's mine. Don't touch the mirror.

He looks up at the old rooftop. Then a deafening horn. A white G-Wagon with music blasting screeches to a stop behind him. MICHAEL (30), in designer shades and a flowery shirt, jumps out and doesn't notice Donald.

MICHAEL *(to the agent at the gate)* Who's selling this compound? I want to buy it! I grew up here! I want to shoot a film on that roof!

Donald slowly turns around and takes off his sunglasses.

DONALD You'll have to outbid me first.

Michael turns. He freezes. His mouth falls open.

MICHAEL ...Chairman?

DONALD *(a slow smile)* Commentator.

MICHAEL DONALD IRWIN?! *(He screams and runs at Donald, lifting him off the ground.)* Look at you! Look at this suit! Who are you now? Governor?!

DONALD *(laughing, being shaken)* Logistics. Put me down!

MICHAEL Logistics with a RANGE ROVER?! Mama Michael said you'd end up a teacher!

Before Donald can answer, a long silver Rolls-Royce glides silently to the kerb. A uniformed driver opens the back door. GEOFFREY (30), in a perfect three-piece suit and glasses, steps out with a folder labelled "PROPERTY PURCHASE: OLD AJEGUNLE COMPOUND." He looks up from the folder at the other two and stops dead.

GEOFFREY *(very calm)* Statistically, this is impossible.

MICHAEL GEOFFREY?!

GEOFFREY Hello, Michael. Hello, Donald. *(beat)* I assume you're both also here to buy this building.

DONALD & MICHAEL Yes.

GEOFFREY *(a long, wobbly breath)* Fifteen years. And we all came back on the same day.

He drops the folder. The three of them crash together in the middle of the street in a tight, shouting, laughing hug. The kids cheer, the hawkers clap and an okada man honks along.

MICHAEL *(wiping tears)* I told you I'd come back with a driver!

GEOFFREY That's a G-Wagon. You promised a Ferrari.

MICHAEL The Ferrari is at home! It's resting!

Donald looks from one to the other. For the first time in fifteen years, his face is completely open.

DONALD So. Who's buying the building?

GEOFFREY *(picking up the folder)* Three boys. Thirty-three point three percent each.

† All scenes

The Vow

EXT. THE OLD ROOFTOP, AJEGUNLE — NIGHT — SEVEN YEARS AGO

The same rusty rooftop, now with three expensive suit jackets thrown over the zinc. The three thirty-year-old millionaires sit where they sat as boys and pass around a bottle of cold Fanta, for old times' sake. Each of them has taken out his torn piece of paper. Donald puts the three pieces together on the zinc. They fit perfectly: THREE BOYS VENTURES — ₦3,000.

MICHAEL *(softly)* Fifteen years in my wallet. Through two cities and one very bad divorce scare.

GEOFFREY Divorce scare? You were never married.

MICHAEL That's the scare! She nearly made me! *(beat)* She left me for a man with a bigger yacht. A yacht, Geoffrey. I don't even like water.

GEOFFREY *(quietly)* My father never loved anybody. Not my mother. Not me. Only his company. I don't think I know how.

They both look at Donald.

DONALD I don't have time for love. Love means somebody can walk out of your door and never come back. *(beat)* I've had enough of that.

Silence.

MICHAEL Then let's make it official. Like we're fifteen again.

DONALD *(standing, taking charge as always)* One. We grow what we've built, together this time. Two. We take care of our families. Three. We never, ever come back to poverty.

MICHAEL Four! No women. No love. No marriage. Love makes a man stupid. I have the yacht to prove it.

GEOFFREY And whoever falls in love first?

DONALD He comes back to this rooftop, hands his piece of the company to the other two and confesses. Out loud. Like a fool.

GEOFFREY And five. The one we already made. We protect each other. Whatever it costs.

Three hands stack on top of the three pieces of paper.

ALL THREE Sworn.

They frame the three pieces separately, one each. Below them, Ajegunle hums and shines.

NARRATOR They merged their companies that year. Irwin Logistics, McClaren Studios and Durose Holdings, each standing beside the others. Donald's company grew into Everys Conglomerate, and in seven years three millionaires became three billionaires. *(beat)* And every year, on the anniversary of the vow, they climbed back onto this rooftop and asked one question. *"Still sworn?"*

GUESS THE TWIST • TICK ONE

Three millionaires just swore never to fall in love. Who breaks the vow first?

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Donald, the controller | ☐ Michael, the charmer |
| ☐ Geoffrey, the quiet one | ☐ None of them |

Revealed in **Scene 36** →

↑ All scenes

The Man who Controls Everything

INT. EVERYS TOWER — BOARDROOM, 40TH FLOOR — DAY — SEVEN YEARS LATER, PRESENT DAY

NARRATOR Seven years later.

Glass walls over the lagoon. Twelve executives sit in silence. DONALD stands at the head of the table and doesn't sit, because sitting is for people who have time.

DONALD The Halbrook Shipping acquisition. Where are we?

EXECUTIVE Sir, the numbers are... mostly stable—

DONALD "Mostly" is a word people use when they've stopped counting. *(He swipes his tablet. Every phone in the room buzzes at once.)* I've moved all your meetings to 6 a.m. tomorrow. All of them. We'll count together.

Groans are swallowed. He walks out. ADAEZE, his PA, matches his pace with practiced speed.

ADAEZE Sir, your mother called. Twice. And you've scheduled lunch for 12:07 again. Nobody eats lunch at 12:07.

DONALD I do.

ADAEZE Sir, with respect, you schedule your sleep.

DONALD Sleep is the only meeting nobody else attends. *(beat)* Who runs Finance Operations while Ross is on leave?

ADAEZE *(checking)* A Miss Emma Reardon. Three months in the company.

DONALD Three months, running Halbrook's accounts during an acquisition. *(cold)* Send me her report. Tonight.

Mama

INT. MAMA IRWIN'S HOUSE, IKEJA GRA — EVENING

A comfortable, quiet home Donald bought for her. MAMA IRWIN (64), gentle and a little fragile, sits on a sofa shelling egusi seeds. Donald sits beside her and takes his shoes off. Here, and only here, he looks like somebody's son.

MAMA IRWIN You came late again.

DONALD I came, Mama. That's the important part.

MAMA IRWIN Your cousin Ngozi has three children. Three. Even the gateman's son is getting married.

DONALD *(smiling)* Mama, not today.

MAMA IRWIN When then? When I'm in the ground? *(She takes his hand.)* Donald. I watched you build walls since you were twelve. Walls keep out thieves. But they also keep out wives.

DONALD I don't need a wife, Mama. I need control. Love is just... losing control with extra steps.

MAMA IRWIN *(laughing softly)* Your father said the same thing. *(beat)* Before he met me.

Donald laughs, but something flickers in his eyes. His phone buzzes. It's Emma Reardon's report, arriving.

The Daughter who Said No

INT. REARDON FAMILY HOME, IKOYI — DINING ROOM — NIGHT

Elegant. Both parents still wear their hospital lanyards. EMMA pushes jollof rice around her plate.

DR. REARDON Emma, one phone call and you're in medical school by January. I'll pay for everything.

EMMA Daddy, I don't want your money. I have a job.

MRS. REARDON You count other people's money for a man who doesn't know your name.

EMMA *(putting down her fork)* Then one day he'll learn it.

DR. REARDON This is how it started with your brother. A dream, a guitar—

EMMA James. His name is James. Six years, and you still can't say it.

Silence. Emma kisses her mother's cheek and takes her bag.

EMMA I'm not running away, Mummy. I'm walking. There's a difference.

She leaves. Her father looks at the empty chair where his son used to sit.

The Mentor's Gift

INT. EVERYS — FINANCE OPERATIONS FLOOR, 14TH FLOOR — MORNING

ROSS (45), kind and fatherly, packs a box. Emma watches, nervous. TOBI hovers with tea.

ROSS You're the sharpest person on this floor. You'll be fine.

EMMA Ross, I've been here three months. Halbrook alone is a monster.

ROSS *(handing her a heavy silver fountain pen)* My first boss gave me this. Sign your first big win with it. And remember the only rule I ever taught you.

EMMA *(smiling)* "Numbers don't lie. People do."

His phone buzzes. The screen shows one letter: "D." He snatches it, and his face goes grey.

ROSS Debby. Family wahala. *(He lifts the box.)* Emma, if anything about Halbrook ever looks strange... *(He stops himself.)* Never mind. Old man's worries.

The lift doors close on his sad eyes.

TOBI That man is hiding something.

EMMA Tobi, everybody is hiding something.

TOBI Yes, but his own is sweating.

Three weeks later. 11:47 p.m. Files pile up, red deadline alerts glow and cold coffee sits on the desk. Emma rubs her eyes. Tobi is half asleep on a chair.

TOBI Emma, go home. Even the generator has gone home.

The computer pings. NEW EMAIL. FROM: Donald Irwin, CEO.

ON SCREEN

Be in my office by 10 a.m.

Nothing else.

TOBI *(suddenly wide awake)* Ehn. Emma. Write your will. Leave me your shoes.

GUESS THE TWIST • TICK ONE

Ross's phone flashed one letter: "D". What's really going on?

☐ Just family wahala with Debby

☐ Someone is blackmailing him

Revealed in **Scene 30** →

Page Eleven

INT. DONALD'S OFFICE, 40TH FLOOR — 9:58 AM

Cold, huge, perfect. Donald reads her report, which is already bleeding red ink. He doesn't look up.

DONALD Sit.

She sits. Ten seconds of pages turning.

DONALD Miss Reardon. Did you write this, or did it happen to you?

EMMA I wrote it, sir.

DONALD Then you should apologise to it. Your forecast is optimistic, your summary is soft, and you missed two deadlines.

EMMA My department lost its manager three weeks ago and nobody replaced him. I'm doing two jobs on one salary.

He looks up. Their eyes meet for the first time.

DONALD Is that an excuse?

EMMA It's a fact. You like facts, don't you? I've read your interviews.

DONALD *(dangerously quiet)* Careful.

EMMA With respect, sir, you've torn me apart without asking one question about the numbers. If you had, you'd know page eleven is the most important page in that report. And you skipped it.

Nobody has spoken to him like this in ten years. Slowly, he turns to page eleven.

DONALD Get out, Miss Reardon.

She stands with her chin high and walks out. The door clicks shut. Donald reads page eleven. In the margin, in small, neat handwriting:

WRITTEN NOTE

**Halbrook — 0.3% missing every month. Same day.
Same amount. Who?**

He reads it three times. Then, for the first time in years, Donald Irwin smiles at something that isn't a profit.

NARRATOR He had read ten thousand reports in his life. This was the first one he would remember.

Asking For a Friend

INT. DONALD'S CAR, THIRD MAINLAND BRIDGE / INT. MICHAEL'S FILM SET — NIGHT — INTERCUT

Donald sits in the back of his car, staring at page eleven again. He calls Michael. Michael answers on a busy film set, with lights and crew everywhere.

MICHAEL Chairman! You never call after 9 p.m. Who died?

DONALD Nobody died. Question. Theoretical.

MICHAEL I love theoretical.

DONALD If a man can't stop thinking about... a report.

MICHAEL A report.

DONALD A report. Written by a... person. And the man reads it three times. Not for the numbers.

A long pause on Michael's end.

MICHAEL Donald. Is this "report" wearing heels?

DONALD *(instantly)* Goodnight, Michael.

MICHAEL Donald! DONALD! Are you breaking the—

Donald hangs up. On set, Michael laughs and turns around. A WOMAN'S VOICE calls from behind a trailer: "Michael, are you coming or not?" His smile disappears. He looks around to check that nobody heard.

MICHAEL *(hissing toward the trailer)* Sophia! I said wait in the car!

NARRATOR Donald thought he was the only one with something to hide. *(beat)*
He wasn't.

Quietly

INT. EVERYS — FINANCE FLOOR — 8:30 PM

The floor is empty. Emma packs up. Expensive footsteps approach. Donald stands there with her report.

EMMA If you've come to fire me, you could have sent another one-line email.

DONALD Page eleven. Explain it.

EMMA Every month, Halbrook loses point three percent. Too small for an audit. Fourteen months running. Same day, same amount. Numbers don't lie.

DONALD *(quietly)* People do.

She blinks. He finished Ross's sentence.

DONALD Investigate it. Quietly. You report to nobody but me. Not your colleagues. Not your manager. Nobody.

EMMA Why me?

DONALD Because you looked at that number and didn't look away. *(turning to go)* And your report was still bad.

EMMA Your email was worse!

He keeps walking and doesn't let her see him smile.

Mallam Isa's Suya

INT. EVERYS — SMALL CONFERENCE ROOM — MIDNIGHT — ONE WEEK LATER

Papers everywhere. Emma is barefoot and drawing arrows on a whiteboard. Donald enters with a parcel wrapped in old newspaper, and the smell of suya fills the room.

EMMA You brought suya? Billionaires eat suya?

DONALD Not this suya. This is Mallam Isa's. Ebute-Metta, by the old railway yard. Best in Lagos. *(He sits and unwraps it.)* When I was sixteen, he gave me suya on credit for a whole year. Never wrote it down.

EMMA Did you pay him back?

DONALD I bought him a house. He still sells suya under the same umbrella. Says the trains are good for business. *(He holds out a stick.)* Eat.

They eat. For a moment, they are just two people at midnight.

EMMA The money goes to a vendor called Crestline Logistics. No trucks. No staff. No office. And the payments are approved inside Every's by someone with senior access.

DONALD *(stops chewing)* How senior?

EMMA Senior enough that if I say a name before I'm sure, I'm finished.

DONALD You have pepper on your lip.

She wipes it, embarrassed. He laughs, a real laugh, rusty from lack of use.

EMMA You laugh?

DONALD Tell nobody. I'll deny it under oath.

The Man in the White Suit

INT. MARCUS VANE'S MANSION, BANANA ISLAND — STUDY — NIGHT

Dark wood, a chessboard and an old framed photo of a trucking company sign: VANE HAULAGE, EST. 1979. MARCUS VANE (52), silver-haired and in a silk robe, makes a call on a burner phone.

MARCUS She found Crestline.

DISTORTED VOICE I'll send her a warning. She'll stop.

MARCUS Warnings are for children. *(He looks at the old photo.)* Twenty years, I've waited. Halbrook bleeds, Every's share price falls, and when it's cheap enough, I buy the boy who bought my father. *(beat)* Don't fail me. Remember who holds Debby's debts.

He hangs up and moves a white knight across the board.

MARCUS Donald Irwin has no weakness. No wife. No children. No heart. *(He smiles.)* Yet.

GUESS THE TWIST • TICK ONE

Who is Marcus Vane's spy inside Every's?

☐

Ross, her mentor

☐

Tobi, her best friend

☐

Adaeze, Donald's PA

☐

Geoffrey

Revealed in **Scene 30** →

Rooftop Night: Still Sworn?

EXT. ROOFTOP, AJEGUNLE — NIGHT — THE ANNIVERSARY OF THE VOW

The rusty rooftop of an old face-me-I-face-you building. It is cleaned up now, with fairy lights, three leather chairs and a small table with three glasses. Below, generators hum. Far away, Victoria Island glitters. Three powerful men in expensive clothes sit where they once sat as hungry boys: DONALD IRWIN, MICHAEL McCLAREN and GEOFFREY DUROSE.

MICHAEL *(raising his glass)* Seven years since the vow, gentlemen. Seven years, and not one woman has caught us.

GEOFFREY Not one.

DONALD Not one.

They clink. Then, by tradition, Michael asks it.

MICHAEL Still sworn?

GEOFFREY *(a tiny pause)* Still sworn.

DONALD *(without blinking)* Still sworn.

MICHAEL Still sworn!

They drink. Donald's phone vibrates in his pocket and he doesn't check it. Michael's phone vibrates and he flips it face down. Geoffrey glances at a folded paper in his jacket and buttons the jacket.

NARRATOR **Three best friends. Three promises. And that night, on the rooftop where it all began, three lies.**

MICHAEL *(leaning in)* So, Donald. Who's the report?

DONALD There's no report.

MICHAEL You called me at 9 p.m. to ask about a report "not for the numbers."

DONALD It was a work question.

MICHAEL Geoffrey, he's blushing. Look at his ears.

Donald's phone buzzes. He glances at it. "E. Reardon: Found something. Call me." He puts it away too fast.

DONALD *(changing the subject, aggressive)* What about you, Michael? Who's "Script Supervisor"? She calls you eleven times a day.

Michael freezes.

MICHAEL She... supervises scripts.

DONALD At 2 a.m.?

MICHAEL Scripts don't sleep, Donald!

They both turn to Geoffrey, who is already standing and buttoning his jacket.

GEOFFREY I have an early board meeting.

MICHAEL It's Saturday.

GEOFFREY *(already leaving)* It's an early Saturday board meeting.

He's gone. Michael and Donald stare at each other, each knowing the other is lying and neither able to say it.

NARRATOR That's the problem with three liars on one rooftop. Nobody can point a finger without three pointing back.

GUESS THE TWIST • TICK ONE

On the rooftop, which of the three brothers is lying?

☐

Donald

☐

Michael

☐

Geoffrey

☐

All three of them

Revealed in **Scene 18** →

↑ All scenes

The Other Secret

INT. DUROSE HOLDINGS — JACOB DUROSE'S OLD OFFICE — SAME NIGHT

MEANWHILE

Same night. Across the lagoon.

Dust sheets cover the furniture. Geoffrey enters alone with a torch. He unlocks a drawer in his late father's desk with a small brass key. Inside is one old photograph. Two young men stand in front of a tiny office: JACOB DUROSE and another man. On the back, in faded ink: "Jacob & Elias. Partners forever. 1998."

GEOFFREY (whispering) Partners? Papa, you told me you built it alone.

His phone lights up with an unknown number. A woman's voice comes through when he answers.

OLIVIA You found it, didn't you, Mr. Durose? Meet me tomorrow. Alone.
V.O.

Click. Geoffrey stares at the photograph. Every brother has a secret now.

TWIST REVEALED · On the rooftop, which of the three brothers is lying? The answer: **All three of them.**
[See what you guessed in Scene 17 →](#)

The First Warning

INT. EMMA'S CAR — EVERYS CAR PARK — NIGHT

Emma throws her bag on the seat. Her phone buzzes with an UNKNOWN NUMBER.

ON SCREEN

STOP LOOKING INTO HALBROOK OR ELSE.

She freezes and scans the dark pillars. A security light flickers. A car door shuts somewhere.

EMMA (whispering) Who are you?

She drives off. Behind her, a black SUV with its headlights off pulls out and follows.

"You're My Responsibility"

INT. DONALD'S OFFICE — NEXT MORNING

Emma walks in without knocking. Adaeze fails to stop her. Emma puts the phone on his desk. As Donald reads it, a second message arrives with PHOTOGRAPHS: Emma at her door, Emma at the supermarket, Emma asleep in traffic.

ON SCREEN

WE SEE YOU, EMMA.

Donald's knuckles go white.

DONALD *(intercom)* Adaeze. Two guards on Miss Reardon. Around the clock. A driver. Armoured car. And move her into one of our serviced apartments in Eko Atlantic, tonight.

EMMA Excuse me? No. Absolutely not.

DONALD It's not a request.

EMMA I didn't refuse my father's money so another man could put me in a cage!

DONALD It's not a cage. It's a—

EMMA A cage with a nicer view is still a cage, Donald!

It's the first time she has used his first name. They both hear it.

DONALD *(quieter)* Someone stood outside your door, Emma.

EMMA Then let me decide how scared to be. One guard. My car. My apartment.

DONALD Two guards.

EMMA One.

DONALD ...Two, and I'll stop talking about the apartment.

EMMA You negotiate like a criminal.

DONALD I learned from them.

She leaves. Donald stares at the door, then presses the intercom again, quietly.

DONALD Adaeze. Send someone from IT. Install location tracking on her company phone. Silently.

ADAEZE *(after a pause)* Sir... she didn't agree to that.

DONALD She'll thank me.

ADAEZE (softly) Sir, nobody has ever thanked anybody for that.

He doesn't answer. Adaeze sighs and makes the call.

NARRATOR It was the kind of decision Donald had made a thousand times: quiet, fast and for her own good. He didn't know yet that it would cost him the one thing he couldn't buy back.

GUESS THE TWIST • TICK ONE

Donald secretly put a tracker on Emma's phone. What will it do?

☐

Save her life later

☐

Destroy their relationship

☐

Nobody ever finds out

Revealed in **Scene 28** →

↑ All scenes

The Mirror

INT. DONALD'S MANSION, LEKKI — MASTER BATHROOM — NIGHT

Donald stands at the mirror in a white vest and practises, like a man rehearsing a lie for court.

DONALD I am not in love. *(beat)* She is an employee. *(beat)* A very irritating employee. *(beat)* With very nice handwriting.

He groans and leans on the sink.

He walks to his bedside, where an old faded photo of MR. IRWIN, smiling in a driver's uniform, stands in a cheap frame among the luxury.

DONALD Papa. You died because you trusted the night. I built a whole life so I'd never trust anything I can't control. *(beat)* And now there's a woman I can't control, and I can't stop thinking about her. *(beat)* What do I do?

The photo, of course, says nothing. Donald switches off the light. In the dark, his phone lights up: "E. Reardon: Goodnight, Mr. Criminal." He smiles at the ceiling like a teenager.

↑ All scenes

Two Plates of Jollof

INT. DONALD'S MANSION — KITCHEN — NIGHT

Emma and Donald have papers spread over the kitchen island, with two plates of jollof and two glasses of zobo. She's laughing at something he said. The intercom buzzes. SECURITY (V.O.): "Sir, Mr. McClaren is at the gate. He says he's already inside."

The front door bangs open.

MICHAEL CHAIRMAN! I'm hungry and my chef has abandoned me!
O.S.

DONALD *(panicking for the first time in his life)* Pantry. Now.

EMMA I'm sorry, the WHAT?

He pushes her gently into the walk-in pantry and shuts the door just as Michael strolls in.

MICHAEL Ah! Jollof! *(He sees two plates.)* Two plates?

DONALD I'm hungry twice.

MICHAEL *(narrowing his eyes, picking up a fork)* Since when do you eat dinner? You schedule dinner. *(He spots a woman's heel lying under the island. He picks it up slowly.)* And since when do you wear a size thirty-eight heel?

DONALD That's Adaeze's.

MICHAEL Adaeze wears flat shoes. She told me she'd rather die than run after you in heels.

Michael's phone rings. He glances at the screen, which says "Script Supervisor", and declines it fast. It rings again. He answers in a hiss, turning away.

MICHAEL *(whispering)* Sophia, I said I'll call you back! ...No, I'm not hiding you, I'm just... I'm at Donald's! ...Yes, I'll bring the script!

He hangs up and turns around. Donald is standing right behind him with his arms folded.

DONALD Sophia.

Michael lifts the size thirty-eight heel.

MICHAEL Adaeze.

A long, silent standoff. Two men, two secrets, no way out. Then, together:

MICHAEL & DONALD Goodnight.

Michael leaves, taking the plate of jollof with him. Donald opens the pantry. Emma is sitting on a bag of rice, crying with laughter.

The Pantry

INT. DONALD'S MANSION — PANTRY / KITCHEN — CONTINUOUS

EMMA *(wiping her tears)* You hid me. In a pantry. Next to the Indomie.

DONALD It was strategic.

EMMA Why? Why am I a secret, Donald? Are you ashamed of me?

He stops smiling.

DONALD *(slowly)* Seven years ago, on the rooftop where I grew up, I swore I'd never fall in love. Michael and Geoffrey swore too. I've never broken a promise in my life.

EMMA *(quietly)* So what am I?

He looks at her for a long time. Then he steps into the pantry.

DONALD You're the first promise I'm afraid I'll break.

He kisses her. Slowly, carefully, between shelves of rice and tomato tins. When they part, she smiles.

EMMA I'm not hiding in your pantry again.

DONALD Noted.

EMMA And you owe me a shoe. Michael stole it.

NARRATOR That night, Donald Irwin broke the promise he'd kept for seven years. And he told nobody. Not his mother. Not his brothers. Not even himself.

A Visit to Ross

INT. ROSS'S HOUSE, SURULERE — DAY

The house is half empty, with pale squares on the walls where pictures used to hang. Ross is thin, unshaven and jumpy. Emma has brought oranges.

EMMA Where's Debby?

ROSS *(too fast)* Her sister. Ibadan.

EMMA Ross, I need advice. Halbrook. Crestline Logistics. Someone senior is—

Ross's teacup rattles against its saucer.

ROSS *(grabbing her hand)* Emma. Leave Halbrook. Please. Give it to Mr. Irwin, give it to anybody, and walk away. Promise me.

EMMA Ross, are you in trouble?

He lets go and forces a smile.

ROSS I'm just an old man who worries too much.

She leaves. Ross pulls a second phone from under a cushion. The message on it reads: "She's still digging. Fix it, or Debby pays."

Framed

INT. EVERYS — BOARDROOM — MORNING

An emergency board meeting. The screen reads: "LOGIN 2:14 A.M. — ~~#~~600 MILLION MOVED TO CRESTLINE — USER: E.REARDON." Emma stands frozen while the board whispers.

BOARD MEMBER A junior analyst gets access to Halbrook, and six hundred million naira disappears under her name?

EMMA I was asleep at 2 a.m.! I'm the one who FOUND the problem!

BOARD MEMBER Perfect way to control an investigation.

Every head turns to Donald. He looks at her for a long, painful moment. His face gives away nothing.

DONALD Miss Reardon. Your badge.

EMMA *(whispering, stunned)* You know I didn't do this.

DONALD Your badge. Now.

Her fingers shake as she unclips it. She walks out with her head high and tears falling.

"You Decide Everything"

INT. EVERYS — STAIRWELL — MOMENTS LATER

Emma runs down the stairs. Donald catches up and takes her arm.

DONALD Emma, listen. Whoever framed you is in that building. If they think they've won, they'll get careless. You're not fired. You're invisible.

EMMA *(pulling away)* You used me as bait.

DONALD I protected you!

EMMA You DECIDED for me! Again! The guards, the apartment, the pantry, and now this! Did it ever occur to you to ASK me? I would have played along! I would have cried on command! But you don't ask, Donald. You arrange.

DONALD Because when I ask, people say no. And then people die!

His voice echoes up the stairwell. Silence.

EMMA *(softly)* I'm not your father's night, Donald. You can't control me so it never happens again.

She walks away. He doesn't follow, because for once he doesn't know what to do.

The Tracker

INT. EMMA'S APARTMENT, LEKKI — NIGHT

A knock. Emma opens the door. JAMES (31) stands there with a guitar on his back.

EMMA James?!

JAMES Daddy called me. First time in six years. He said, "Your sister is in trouble, and she won't talk to me."

She falls into his arms. Later, they sit on the floor eating Indomie. James picks up her company phone.

JAMES Your battery dies fast. *(He scrolls.)* Emma, what's "SysLoc"? It's been running in the background for two weeks. Location. Microphone permission. Sending to an Every's server.

Emma takes the phone. She looks at the app and goes pale.

EMMA *(barely a whisper)* He tracked me.

NARRATOR Every guard, every driver, every locked door had been love, in the only language Donald knew. But Emma had never learned that language. And she never wanted to.

The Breakup

EXT. DONALD'S MANSION — GATE — NIGHT — HEAVY RAIN

Emma stands in the rain. Donald rushes out with an umbrella, and she pushes it away. She holds up the phone with SysLoc on the screen.

EMMA Two weeks. Every step. Every street. Did you listen to my phone calls too? To my brother?

DONALD No. I swear. It was only location. Emma, someone is taking pictures of you—

EMMA And so were YOU!

Thunder. He has no answer.

EMMA You know what the worst part is? I was falling in love with you. *(Her voice breaks.)* But you don't love me, Donald. You want to own me, like a port. Like a tower. Like everything else you control.

DONALD *(desperate)* That's not true.

EMMA Then let me go.

She deletes SysLoc in front of him and presses the phone into his hand.

EMMA If you want to know where I am, ask me. *(beat)* That's what people who love you do. They ask.

She walks into the rain. He stands there, soaked, holding a phone that can't find her any more.

NARRATOR Donald Irwin had controlled every deal of his life. It took one woman walking away in the rain to show him that the only things worth having are the ones you can't control.

TWIST REVEALED · Donald secretly put a tracker on Emma's phone. What will it do? The answer: Destroy their relationship. [See what you guessed in Scene 20 →](#)

Geoffrey Knows

INT. DONALD'S MANSION — STUDY — LATER THAT NIGHT

Donald sits in the dark, still wet. Geoffrey lets himself in and turns on one lamp.

GEOFFREY You look terrible.

DONALD *(not looking up)* Geoffrey. Can I tell you something? Something I swore...

Geoffrey sits. Donald opens his mouth to confess, and the words don't come.

DONALD ...Never mind.

GEOFFREY *(quietly)* Good. Because I'm not here about a woman. *(He opens his laptop.)*
The 2:14 login used Emma's password, but it came from Terminal 14-01. Ross's office. His key card was swiped at 1:58 a.m.

DONALD Ross is on leave.

GEOFFREY His card isn't. *(beat)* And Donald, one more thing. Three weeks ago, I did something to protect Every's. Something I didn't tell you about.

DONALD *(sharp)* What did you do?

GEOFFREY If anyone ever asks you to sign Every's away, sign it. Don't argue. Just sign. And call me.

DONALD What does that even—

GEOFFREY *(standing, buttoning his jacket)* You're not the only one with secrets, brother. Goodnight.

He leaves. Donald stares after him, completely lost.

GUESS THE TWIST • TICK ONE

Geoffrey said: "If anyone asks you to sign Every's away, sign it." Why?

- ☐ He's secretly working with Marcus
- ☐ He has a hidden plan to protect Every's
- ☐ He wants Every's for himself

Revealed in **Scene 41** →

The Confession

INT. EVERYS — ROSS'S OFFICE — 2 AM

Emma sneaks in with Tobi's borrowed badge and a phone torch. Under the bottom drawer, taped flat, she finds a black notebook full of dates and amounts, with "CRESTLINE" written again and again in Ross's handwriting.

EMMA *(breaking)* No. Not you. Not you, Ross.

Later that night, in pouring rain outside Ross's house in Surulere, Emma bangs on the door. Ross opens it, sees the notebook and seems to shrink.

EMMA Look at me and say it wasn't you.

ROSS *(after a long silence)* It was me.

EMMA WHY?!

ROSS Debby's father borrowed from the wrong people. Marcus Vane bought the debt. All of it. Then he came smiling. "Pay me with information, Ross, or Debby pays another way." *(sobbing)* He sent me photos of her sleeping, Emma. Then he took her. She's not in Ibadan. I don't know where she is.

EMMA You framed me!

ROSS He told me to. I sent the warnings to scare you off! To keep you SAFE!

EMMA You gave me your pen!

ROSS *(on his knees in the rain)* Numbers don't lie, Emma. People do. *(He looks up, destroyed.)* I'm the people.

Emma stands over him, shaking. Then she does what nobody expects. She crouches down in the rain.

EMMA Then stop lying. Help me get Debby back, and help me end Marcus Vane.

TWIST REVEALED · Ross's phone flashed one letter: "D". What's really going on? The answer: **Someone is blackmailing him.** [See what you guessed in Scene 11 →](#)

TWIST REVEALED · Who is Marcus Vane's spy inside Every's? The answer: **Ross, her mentor.** [See what you guessed in Scene 16 →](#)

On Her Terms

INT. DONALD'S OFFICE — MORNING

Donald is at the window. The door opens. Emma walks in with Ross behind her. Donald's face moves through relief, longing and then confusion when he sees Ross.

DONALD Emma—

EMMA *(raising a hand)* I'm not here as your... whatever I was. I'm here as the analyst who found your thief. *(She drops the black notebook on his desk.)* And I'm here with my terms.

DONALD Your terms.

EMMA One. Ross helps us, and he doesn't go to prison until Debby is safe. Two. I lead this investigation. Not you. Three. You don't decide anything about me without asking me first. Nothing.

A long pause. Donald Irwin has never accepted anyone's terms in his life.

DONALD *(quietly)* And if I say no?

EMMA Then you can catch Marcus Vane without the only person who knows how.

He looks at her. Then he sits down, which he never does, and he's taking the order.

DONALD ...Tell me the plan.

Who Marcus Is

INT. DONALD'S OFFICE — CONTINUOUS

ROSS Marcus has waited twenty years. You bought his father's company.

DONALD Vane Haulage. It was bankrupt. I bought it fairly.

ROSS You bought it, and old Mr. Vane died the next year. Marcus says you killed his father with a signature. *(beat)* There's more, sir. But he never told me the rest. He only says, "Irwin doesn't even know what his own father was carrying."

Donald goes very still.

DONALD What does that mean?

ROSS I don't know, sir. But he smiles every time he says it.

Emma looks at Donald. For the first time, she sees fear on his face.

The Plan

INT. DONALD'S MANSION — STUDY — NIGHT

Donald, Emma, Michael, Geoffrey and Ross sit around the table. Michael keeps looking from Emma to Donald with an enormous grin.

MICHAEL *(whispering to Donald)* Size thirty-eight?

DONALD *(whispering back)* Script Supervisor?

They both go silent.

EMMA Ross feeds Marcus false numbers that make Every's look weak. Marcus will try to buy at Friday's shareholders' meeting. Geoffrey freezes Crestline. Michael brings every camera in Lagos.

MICHAEL If you're going to destroy a man, do it in good lighting.

EMMA And Donald exposes him live. With evidence.

GEOFFREY And Debby?

ROSS *(quietly)* Marcus will move her before Friday. He always moves people where nobody looks.

EMMA *(to Donald)* Is that okay with you? *(beat)* I'm asking.

Donald looks at her. Something in him breaks open.

DONALD It's perfect. Thank you for asking.

Michael's jaw drops, and Geoffrey hides a smile. Donald Irwin has just said "thank you for asking."

Suya and Trains

EXT. MALLAM ISA'S SUYA STAND, EBUTE-METTA — NIGHT — THURSDAY

Smoke and orange coals under a faded umbrella, with old train tracks behind. Emma sits on a bench beside MALLAM ISA (60s).

MALLAM ISA So you are the one. *(He laughs.)* Donald has been coming here for twenty-one years. Always alone. Last month, he ordered two.

EMMA *(smiling sadly)* What was he like? When he was a boy?

MALLAM ISA Hungry. Proud. He would count the money in his pocket three times before he asked the price. *(beat)* He has never once in his life been late to pay. But he has always been late to rest.

Emma laughs softly. A train horn sounds far away.

MALLAM ISA You love him.

EMMA I'm angry with him.

MALLAM ISA *(turning the meat)* My daughter, those two are cousins.

Behind them, in the dark between the train sheds, the black SUV's engine starts.

NARRATOR **Mallam Isa had watched a hungry boy become a billionaire. He was about to watch that billionaire's whole world taken from his bench.**

Emma walks to her car holding a wrapped parcel of suya. The SUV screeches up and three masked men jump out. She screams and swings the bag. Mallam Isa runs out shouting and is shoved to the ground. Emma's phone falls in the gutter. The SUV door slams. Tyres scream.

The suya parcel lies on the road, smoke still rising.

GUESS THE TWIST • TICK ONE

Emma has been taken. How will Donald find her?

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ The tracker | ☐ Ross tells him |
| ☐ A secret code from Emma | ☐ Marcus makes a mistake |

Revealed in **Scene 37** →

Friday

INT. EVERYS — GRAND HALL — SHAREHOLDERS' MEETING — DAY

Hundreds of shareholders, TV cameras and flashes. MARCUS VANE walks in wearing a white suit and an easy smile. Donald stands at the podium. Emma's seat is empty, and Donald keeps looking at it.

DONALD *(into the mic)* Ladies and gentlemen. For fourteen months, someone has been stealing from this company to make it cheap enough to buy. *(He points.)* Marcus Vane.

Uproar. Geoffrey's evidence fills the screen. Marcus doesn't flinch. He walks up to the podium as if he owns the stage and slides his phone across to Donald.

On the screen is a VIDEO. Emma is tied to a chair in a dark shed, with bruises on her face.

MARCUS *(smiling for the cameras, whispering)* Sign Every's over to me for one naira by midnight. Or you'll never see her again.

He waves to the crowd and leaves. Donald's hand trembles on the podium.

[↑ All scenes](#)

Powerless

INT. EVERYS — BACKSTAGE — CONTINUOUS

Donald stumbles through a door and braces himself against the wall. He can't breathe. Flashback: the kerosene lamp, the policemen, his mother on the floor.

DONALD *(gasping)* Not again. Not again. Not again.

He grabs his phone and opens the tracking dashboard. "SysLoc — DEVICE NOT FOUND. App deleted."

DONALD *(laughing bitterly, almost crying)* Of course. Of course she deleted it. Because of me.

Michael and Geoffrey burst in.

MICHAEL Donald—

DONALD *(exploding)* I love her!

Silence.

DONALD I love her. I broke it. The vow. The rooftop. All of it. Take my share. Take the certificate. Take everything I own. Just help me find her. *(His voice cracks.)* Please. I've never said please to anyone in my life.

Michael stares at him. Then he grabs Donald's face with both hands.

MICHAEL You IDIOT. You think we didn't know? You smile at your phone like a JJC in love!

GEOFFREY *(calm, firm)* Rooftop. Promise number five. We protect each other. Whatever it costs.

MICHAEL *(opening his mouth)* And Donald, since we're confessing, I also have to tell you —

GEOFFREY *(sharply)* Not now, Michael.

Michael closes his mouth. His phone buzzes in his pocket. "Script Supervisor." He silences it.

TWIST REVEALED · Three millionaires just swore never to fall in love. Who breaks the vow first? The answer: **Donald, the controller.** [See what you guessed in Scene 7 →](#)

The Message in the Video

INT. EVERYS — BACKSTAGE — MOMENTS LATER

Ross bursts in, bloodied and panting.

ROSS They sent another video. Proof of life.

They crowd around the phone. Emma, tied and bruised, speaks to the camera while a masked man holds a gun to her side.

EMMA Donald. I'm alive. Do what they say. *(She looks straight into the lens.)* And tell
ON VIDEO Mallam Isa I'm sorry I dropped his suya. I can still smell it... even over the trains.
(beat) Read page eleven, Donald. Read it properly this time.

The video cuts. Everyone looks confused, except Donald.

MICHAEL Page eleven? Is she delirious?

DONALD *(slowly, his eyes widening)* No. She's talking to me. In our language. *(He paces, thinking aloud.)* "Smell the suya over the trains." She's close to Mallam Isa's, near the railway. "Page eleven." Her note on page eleven was about the same day, the same amount, every month. *(He grabs Geoffrey.)* Halbbrook's warehouse lease. Which property does Crestline rent every month?

GEOFFREY *(typing fast, then freezing)* Shed 11. The old Ebute-Metta railway goods yard. Two hundred metres from Mallam Isa's stand.

Donald closes his eyes. Then he laughs once, a broken laugh.

DONALD I tracked her for two weeks and found nothing. I listened to her once, and I found her.

TWIST REVEALED · Emma has been taken. How will Donald find her? The answer: **A secret code from Emma.** [See what you guessed in Scene 34 →](#)

Sign It

INT. MICHAEL'S RANGE ROVER — NIGHT — SPEEDING

Rain and wipers. Michael drives like a madman. Geoffrey has a laptop on his knees. Donald is on the phone with Marcus.

MARCUS Have you signed?
V.O.

Donald looks at Geoffrey. Geoffrey nods, very calm.

GEOFFREY (whispering) Remember what I told you. Sign it.

A document pops up on Donald's tablet: TRANSFER OF ALL SHARES — EVERYS HOLDINGS LIMITED — TO VANE CAPITAL — CONSIDERATION: #1.

Donald hesitates. He's looking at twenty years of his life. Then he signs it without another word.

DONALD It's done. Everys is yours. Now let her go.

MARCUS (delighted) Twenty years. (beat) I'll consider it.
V.O.

Click.

MICHAEL (horrified) Donald, you just gave away EVERYTHING!

DONALD (staring at the rain) I gave away a company. I can build another one. (beat) I can't build another Emma.

NARRATOR Twenty-five years earlier, a boy swore he would never be powerless again. Tonight he gave away everything he had, and for the first time in his life, he felt free.

GUESS THE TWIST • TICK ONE

Marcus says Donald doesn't know what his father was carrying.
What was it?

☐ Money he had stolen☐ Forty workers' wages☐ Secret documentsRevealed in **Scene 39** →

What His Father Was Carrying

INT. SHED 11, RAILWAY GOODS YARD — NIGHT

A huge, dark train shed with rusted carriages. Emma is tied to a chair, and DEBBY is tied up beside her. Emma has been quietly sawing her rope against a sharp edge of a rail spike for an hour. MARCUS VANE enters, triumphant, holding his phone.

MARCUS He signed. Every Conglomerate is mine. For one naira. *(laughing)* The great Donald Irwin, finally powerless.

EMMA Why do you hate him this much?

MARCUS *(pulling up a crate and sitting)* Do you know what his father did for a living? He was a driver for my father. Vane Haulage. Every payday, someone carried the workers' wages from the depot at night. Cash. *(beat)* My father was too cheap to pay for a guard. So he sent a driver. Alone.

Emma's breath catches.

MARCUS That night, robbers stopped him. He refused to hand over the bag. Forty men's wages. Forty families. He fought them, and they killed him. *(He smiles coldly.)* And my father told the police the driver stole the money himself. His widow never received a kobo.

EMMA *(horrified)* And Donald doesn't know.

MARCUS Twenty years later, the driver's son bought my father's company like it was a bag of rice. Never knew whose company it was. *(leaning in)* So tonight, I took everything from him. The way he took everything from me.

EMMA *(steady, despite her tears)* No. Your father stole from a dead man and lied about him. And you've spent your life trying to make the son pay for your father's sin. *(beat)* You're not avenging anyone, Marcus. You're just your father, in a nicer suit.

Marcus's smile dies. He stands and raises his hand to strike her, and her rope snaps.

TWIST REVEALED · Marcus says Donald doesn't know what his father was carrying. What was it? The answer: **Forty workers' wages.** [See what you guessed in Scene 38 →](#)

She Doesn't Wait to Be Saved

INT. SHED 11 — CONTINUOUS

Emma swings the broken chair leg and smashes the only hanging work lamp. The shed goes PITCH BLACK.

MARCUS GET HER!

Chaos and shouting. Torches swing. Emma drags Debby behind a rusted carriage. Outside, headlights flood the yard doors. A car horn blasts once, then twice. It's Donald's signal.

Through a crack, Emma sees Donald at the doors. He isn't charging in. He's waiting, looking straight at the dark corner where she's hiding, as if he knows she has a plan.

EMMA *(whispering to herself, smiling through tears)* He's waiting. He's actually waiting.

She flashes Debby's phone torch twice toward the doors, their signal. Donald nods to Inspector Bello's officers, and they pour in.

Marcus grabs a gun from a henchman and aims into the dark toward Emma's torchlight. Ross, unseen until now, throws himself in front of her. BANG. Ross falls, clutching his shoulder.

EMMA ROSS!

Donald crashes into Marcus. The gun skids away. Michael kicks it under a carriage. Inspector Bello cuffs Marcus, who is still laughing.

The Empty Box

INT. SHED 11 — MOMENTS LATER

MARCUS *(on his knees, cuffed, laughing)* Arrest me, then! I'll get bail by morning! And when I get out, I'll still own Everys! He signed it! On camera!

Geoffrey steps forward and adjusts his glasses.

GEOFFREY You own Everys Holdings Limited.

MARCUS Exactly!

GEOFFREY Three weeks ago, I moved every port, every network, every naira of EveryPay and every brick in Eko Atlantic into a new parent company. *(beat)* It's called Three Boys Ventures. *(He smiles slightly.)* Everys Holdings Limited is an empty box, Marcus. You paid one naira for a shell. Which, I believe, is your speciality.

Marcus's face collapses. Donald turns slowly to Geoffrey.

DONALD You restructured my entire company... without telling me?

GEOFFREY You'd have tried to control it.

Michael bursts out laughing. Even Donald, after a moment, laughs. Then he runs to Emma.

NARRATOR Three boys had torn one piece of paper into three. Twenty-two years later, that piece of paper had just saved all of them.

TWIST REVEALED · Geoffrey said: "If anyone asks you to sign Everys away, sign it." Why? The answer: He has a hidden plan to protect Everys. [See what you guessed in Scene 29 →](#)

The Truth About Papa

EXT. RAILWAY GOODS YARD — AMBULANCE LIGHTS — NIGHT

Paramedics load Ross onto a stretcher, and Debby holds his hand. Emma, wrapped in a blanket, catches Ross's hand as he passes.

ROSS *(weakly)* Numbers don't lie, Emma...

EMMA But people change. *(She kisses his forehead.)* Thank you.

She turns. Donald stands there in the rain, afraid to touch her, as if she might break or vanish.

DONALD I'm asking this time. *(beat)* Can I hold you?

She walks into his arms.

EMMA *(into his chest)* Donald... Marcus told me something. About your father.

She tells him, and we stay on Donald's face as he hears it. Confusion becomes shock, then grief, and finally a slow, aching pride.

DONALD *(barely able to speak)* He didn't run. He was carrying forty families' wages, and he didn't run. *(He breaks down.)* My whole life, I thought he died for nothing. Powerless.

EMMA *(holding his face)* He wasn't powerless, Donald. He was the bravest man on that road. *(beat)* You get it from him.

Donald Irwin, the man who stopped crying at twelve, cries in the rain in her arms.

GUESS THE TWIST • TICK ONE

Donald is about to propose with fireworks and a helicopter. What will Emma say?

☐ Yes, straight away

☐ Yes, with a condition

☐ No

Revealed in **Scene 43** →

The Proposal That Went Wrong

EXT. EKO ATLANTIC — PRIVATE HELIPAD — SUNSET — ONE MONTH LATER

Everything is perfect, because Donald planned it to the second. There are rose petals, a string quartet, a helicopter waiting, a photographer in the bushes and fireworks timed on a tablet Adaeze is holding. Emma steps out of a car, and her jaw drops.

ADAEZE (into her earpiece) Fireworks in sixty seconds, sir.

Donald kneels and opens a ring box with a diamond the size of a grape.

DONALD Emma Reardon. I've planned every second of this. The quartet starts at 6:14. The helicopter takes us to dinner at 6:31. The fireworks go at 6:15. Will you marry me?

Silence. The quartet waits. The fireworks wait. Emma looks at the helicopter, the timers, the photographer. Her eyes fill with tears.

EMMA (softly) No.

A gasp from the bushes from the photographer. Adaeze drops the tablet. The fireworks go off at 6:15 anyway, booming over an empty, heartbroken silence.

EMMA (crying) Not like this, Donald. (She turns and walks away.)

Donald kneels alone as fireworks explode over his head.

NARRATOR The most powerful man in Lagos had just been told no. (beat) And he had no idea why.

TWIST REVEALED · Donald is about to propose with fireworks and a helicopter. What will Emma say? The answer: **No**. [See what you guessed in Scene 42 →](#)

GUESS THE TWIST • TICK ONE

Emma said no and walked away. What happens next?

- ☐ Donald gives up on her
- ☐ Donald plans an even bigger proposal
- ☐ Emma proposes to Donald

Revealed in **Scene 44** →

The Second Ask

EXT. MALLAM ISA'S SUYA STAND, EBUTE-METTA — NIGHT — SAME EVENING

Smoke, coals and a train horn in the distance. Donald, still in his proposal suit, sits alone on the bench, defeated. Mallam Isa silently hands him a stick of suya.

DONALD She said no, Mallam. I gave her everything. A helicopter. Fireworks. A quartet.

MALLAM ISA You gave her a schedule.

Donald looks up. Emma is standing at the edge of the light, in jeans and holding a wrapped parcel of suya.

EMMA You planned every second, Donald. You decided the place, the time, the answer, even the fireworks. You were still controlling it. *(She walks closer.)* I don't want to be your best-run project. I want to be your partner.

She kneels in front of him on the dusty ground and opens her hand. In it is a simple silver ring with a tiny engraving.

EMMA This is my ring. Read it.

WRITTEN NOTE

Page 11.

EMMA Donald Irwin. I'm not asking you to control our life. I'm asking you to share it. *(beat)* Will you marry me?

Donald stares at her. The billionaire who controls everything has just been proposed to by the woman he couldn't control. He laughs and cries at the same time.

DONALD Yes. *(beat)* Yes! On one condition.

EMMA *(laughing)* Of course there's a condition.

DONALD We eat suya at every anniversary. Here. With Mallam.

MALLAM ISA *(turning the meat, grinning)* On credit.

They kiss under the old umbrella while the train passes. Mallam Isa wipes his eyes and pretends it's the smoke.

TWIST REVEALED • Emma said no and walked away. What happens next? The answer: **Emma proposes to Donald.** [See what you guessed in Scene 43 →](#)

The Fool on the Rooftop

EXT. AJEGUNLE ROOFTOP — NIGHT — ROOFTOP NIGHT, ONE YEAR LATER

The fairy lights and three leather chairs are back. Michael and Geoffrey sit and wait. Donald comes up the stairs holding his torn, framed piece of the old ₦3,000 share certificate. Emma waits by the stairs, smiling.

MICHAEL *(delighted)* The Chairman has arrived to pay his debt!

DONALD *(standing before them, solemn)* By the rules of this rooftop, I, Donald Irwin, confess. I fell in love. I broke the vow. *(He places his piece on the table.)* Here is my share.

Michael picks it up, slowly and dramatically, then puts it back in Donald's hand.

MICHAEL Keep it. You'll need it to pay for my wedding gift. I want a whole port.

They laugh and hug like boys again. Then, by tradition:

MICHAEL *(raising his glass)* Well. One down. *(turning to Geoffrey)* Still sworn?

GEOFFREY *(pause)* ...Still sworn.

MICHAEL *(too loud)* STILL SWORN!

They drink. Donald watches them both over his glass and smiles knowingly.

CLOSE ON Michael's pocket, where his phone lights up: "Script Supervisor ❤️ — Where are you? You promised you'd tell them tonight." He quietly turns the phone off.

CLOSE ON Geoffrey's jacket. He slips out the old photograph of his father and Elias Hart. A new message glows on his phone: "My father died building the fortune you inherited. And I think your father killed him. — Olivia Hart."

Geoffrey's face hardens. He puts the phone away and smiles at his brothers as if nothing has happened.

NARRATOR One brother has confessed. Two are still lying. And on this rooftop, the next lie will cost much more than a piece of paper. *(beat)* Because Michael's secret could destroy his career... *(beat)* and Geoffrey's could destroy his entire family.

The camera rises from the rooftop, over Ajegunle and across the lagoon to the lights of Lagos.

THE SWORN BACHELORS. PART TWO: MICHAEL × SOPHIA. "WINGS UNCLIPPED."

END

↑ All scenes

Answer key

Scene 7 → revealed in Scene 36

Three millionaires just swore never to fall in love. Who breaks the vow first? **Donald, the controller.** Donald fell for Emma and confessed backstage when she was taken. But Michael and Geoffrey were hiding secrets too.

Scene 17 → revealed in Scene 18

On the rooftop, which of the three brothers is lying? **All three of them.** Donald is hiding Emma, Michael is hiding Sophia, and Geoffrey is hiding a photo of his father with a dead man called Elias Hart.

Scene 11 → revealed in Scene 30

Ross's phone flashed one letter: "D". What's really going on? **Someone is blackmailing him.** Marcus Vane bought Debby's family debts and used them to force Ross to spy on Every's.

Scene 16 → revealed in Scene 30

Who is Marcus Vane's spy inside Every's? **Ross, her mentor.** Emma found Ross's black notebook, taped under his desk drawer.

Scene 20 → revealed in Scene 28

Donald secretly put a tracker on Emma's phone. What will it do? **Destroy their relationship.** James found it, Emma deleted it in front of Donald and walked away in the rain. It never saved anyone.

Scene 29 → revealed in Scene 41

Geoffrey said: "If anyone asks you to sign Every's away, sign it." Why? **He has a hidden plan to protect Every's.** He had quietly moved everything into Three Boys Ventures. Marcus paid one naira for an empty box.

Scene 34 → revealed in Scene 37

Emma has been taken. How will Donald find her? **A secret code from Emma.** "Suya over the trains" and "page eleven" led him to Shed 11 at the railway yard. He found her by listening.

Scene 38 → revealed in Scene 39

Marcus says Donald doesn't know what his father was carrying. What was it? **Forty workers' wages.** Donald's father died protecting forty families' wages. Marcus's father called him a thief.

Scene 42 → revealed in Scene 43

Donald is about to propose with fireworks and a helicopter. What will Emma say? **No.** She said no, because he had planned and controlled every second of it.

Scene 43 → revealed in Scene 44

Emma said no and walked away. What happens next? **Emma proposes to Donald**. She knelt at Mallam Isa's suya stand with a ring engraved "Page 11".

Your detective score

Count your correct guesses. **0–3**: Marcus fooled you. **4–6**: sharp, like Emma. **7–10**: you think like Geoffrey, so watch out for Part Two.

Coming next: The Sworn Bachelors, Part Two: Michael × Sophia, "Wings Unclipped".